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Democracy Dies in Darkness

SATURDAY, MARCH 29, 2025 • \$4

Signal chat flouted U.S. rules, say ex-officials

Agency policies differ but don't allow using app to share secret information

BY WARREN P. STROBEL,
MISSY RYAN
AND HANNAH NATANSON

The Yemen attack timeline that Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth posted to a Signal chat group would have been so highly classified, under Pentagon guidelines, that the details should have been restricted to a special, compartmented channel with its own code word and with access tightly limited, according to former Defense Department officials.

Hegseth and other senior Trump administration officials have denied that the data they shared in a Signal group, which included the timing of weapons strikes against Yemen's Houthis and intelligence information shared by Israel on the whereabouts of a top Houthi operative, was classified.

"These are indeed highly detailed operational plans for war," said one of the former officials, who like others spoke on the condition of anonymity because of the issue's sensitivity. "Twenty-five years, I have never known them not to be classified. And usually this operational level of detail is further restricted to those with a need-to-know."

"I don't care what DOD says — that's classified info," a second former official said.

Current and former U.S. defense and intelligence officials described the lack of operational security, which leaked when the editor in chief of the Atlantic magazine was inadvertently added to the chat group among President Donald Trump's top

SEE **SIGNAL** ON **A6**

Myanmar rocked by 7.7-magnitude quake



SAI AUNG MAIN/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

An earthquake survivor waits for medical treatment at a hospital in Naypyidaw, the capital of Myanmar. The lunchtime temblor killed at least 144 people, according to the country's military junta, which called on the world for help. Tremors were felt as far away as Bangkok, where a building under construction collapsed. **Story A8**

Smithsonian order draws condemnation, disbelief

BY MANUEL ROIG-FRANZIA,
KYLE SWENSON,
EMMA UBER
AND GAYA GUPTA

President Donald Trump's sweeping executive order to eliminate what he considers "anti-American ideology" from the Smithsonian Institution cast the world's largest museum, education and research complex into a state of confusion Friday, just as streams of tourists poured into

Washington, drawn by idyllic spring weather and the appearance of the city's famed cherry blossoms.

Trump's edict, issued late Thursday, marks his second recent attempt to mold America's cultural life, following his decision last month to purge the Smithsonian Center board of his predecessor's appointees and install himself as chairman.

Both acts, unprecedented in American history, have drawn

heated condemnation from Democrats, including some current and former members of the Smithsonian Board of Regents. Outside some of the country's most beloved attractions on Friday — places such as the Smithsonian American Art Museum and the National Museum of African American History and Culture — there was an air of bewilderment tinged with anger.

"The Smithsonian has been preserving and sharing the

American story for over 175 years, and I'll continue to support the independence of this critical institution," Sen. Catherine Cortez Masto (D-Nevada), who sits on the Smithsonian board, said in a statement emailed Friday to The Washington Post. "President Trump's attempts to rewrite history are a weak, pathetic effort to distract from his disastrous plans to cut Medicaid and use tariffs to raise costs for middle class Amer-

SEE **SMITHSONIAN** ON **A5**

RFK Jr. forces out top vaccine regulator

BY DAN DIAMOND

The Trump administration on Friday pushed out Peter Marks, the nation's top vaccine regulator and an architect of the U.S. program to rapidly develop coronavirus vaccines, a move that comes as Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. continues his overhaul of the nation's health and science agencies amid a worsening U.S. outbreak of measles.

Marks, who joined the Food and Drug Administration in 2012 and had overseen its Center for Biologics Evaluation and Research since 2016, was offered the choice to resign or be fired, according to two people who spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe a sensitive situation.

He opted to resign, with an effective departure date of April 5.

Marks is leaving his post with a "heavy heart," he wrote in his resignation letter Friday, which was obtained by The Washington Post.

The longtime regulator wrote that he was particularly worried about the measles outbreak in Texas, which "reminds us of what happens when confidence in

SEE **FDA** ON **A5**

'Blitzkrieg': Trump's pace designed to overwhelm the opposition. **A4**



MELINA MARA/THE WASHINGTON POST

A protest organized by the "Tesla Takedown" movement in Corte Madera, California, last weekend.

Musk's Tesla is uniting anti-Trump movement

BY TRISHA THADANI
AND PRANSHU VERMA

Jennifer Cousins has a laundry list of grievances against President Donald Trump: the dismantling of the Department of Education, the administration's anti-transgender policy, and deep cuts to the Social Security Administration.

The 48-year-old Florida resident was unsure where to direct her ire. But an obvious outlet has emerged: Elon Musk's Tesla.

"Musk is a bigger threat to democracy than Trump is at this point," said Cousins, a longtime activist who organized an anti-Tesla rally in a deep-red district in Central Florida last weekend, drawing about 100 people. "The goal is to make him broke."

Musk has become the most po-

larizing figure of Trump's second term, overseeing dramatic cuts and sweeping layoffs within the federal government through his U.S. DOGE Service. As public sentiment toward Musk has curdled, activists have taken aim at the electric-vehicle company that undergirds much of the billionaire's wealth — transforming Tesla into the symbol of a new anti-Trump movement.

A groundswell of Tesla protests has erupted across the globe, many launched by groups that have emerged in recent months. Activists created "Tesla Take-down," a clearinghouse for smaller protests, earlier this year. Rise and Resist, a social advocacy group

SEE **TESLA** ON **A12**

DOGE: Musk says \$1 trillion in cuts won't harm federal services. **A11**

Researchers aim to take the guesswork out of measuring pain

BY MARK JOHNSON

Madison Evans was 16 when she first felt sharp pain in her lower pelvis, pain that radiated through her back and grew so severe that some days she could not get out of bed.

Instead of asking the Severna Park, Maryland, adolescent to assess her pain, pediatricians told her "you'll grow out of it."

She suffered for nearly 15 years until a doctor finally grasped the intensity of her discomfort and diagnosed endometriosis, a chronic condition that affects 1 in 10 women of childbearing age.

Researchers are now trying to find something the doctors who treated Evans lacked: objective indicators of pain that will enable physicians to quantify it as they do heart rate and blood pressure.

The wave of research into these indicators, known as biomarkers, carries implications for the nearly 1 in 4 Americans who live with chronic pain. It may also give voice to infants and others who are unable to tell doctors what they feel.

Measuring pain, one of the most fundamental tasks in medicine, remains one of the least precise, a shortcoming that

helped fuel the nation's opioid crisis. In an era of genomic medicine and artificial intelligence, doctors still ask patients to rate their anguish from 0 to 10 or, in the case of very young children, with cartoon faces, ranging from smiley to frowny.

Studies have shown that these efforts are undermined by biases that have led the medical community to consistently underesti-

mate the suffering of women and minorities, especially Black Americans.

Scientists hope to identify biomarkers among the proteins, hormones and metabolites that have been linked to pain. One researcher has been developing a way to measure the pain sensations transmitted by nerve fibers in the body.

SEE **PAIN** ON **A16**

IN THE NEWS

Eyes to the north Vice President JD Vance upbraided Denmark over its stewardship of Greenland during a visit to the island. **A16**

Israel strikes Beirut suburb The country said it targeted a Hezbollah drone facility in response to rocket fire, as fears mount that the four-month-long ceasefire is at risk. **A10**

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A Harvard researcher has been detained by ICE and may be deported back to Russia. **A2**
Elon Musk was sued by Wisconsin's attorney general over planned payments to voters. **A6**

THE WORLD
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Ukrainian officials said a new minerals proposal from the U.S. has onerous conditions. **A10**

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Google keeps profiting off advertisements that send people to IRS look-alike sites. Learn how to avoid being tricked. **A11**
Tariffs on cars are coming, and analysts say certain brands and more-affordable models will be the first to see higher prices. **A12**

THE REGION
The president signed an executive order aimed at immigration enforcement and curbing crime in the District. **B1**
A federal judge ordered the release of a D.C. couple from Venezuela detained this month despite their temporary protected status. **B1**

STYLE
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Homeland Security Secretary Kristi L. Noem wore a \$50,000 Rolex during her visit this week to El Salvador's most notorious prison, which caused a stir. **C1**

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